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Hearts and Minds on the Durand Line

A Tribal Fund for the Pakistan-Afghanistan Border Is Critical to Winning the War on Terror

By Ashley Bommer
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The United States has counterterrorism operations in places all over the world -- but not in Pakistan, the center of world terrorism. Last month, Defense Secretary Robert Gates made an offer: "We remain ready, willing and able to assist the Pakistanis and to partner with them, to provide additional training, to conduct joint operations, should they desire to do so." Within hours, fearing a backlash on Pakistani soil, President Pervez Musharraf rejected the American offer.

But there is another counterterrorism strategy option for Pakistan: Empower millions of oppressed people who live there to be native allies against the insurgents, through the establishment of a Global Tribal Fund.

We cannot win the war on terrorism when we are losing the border to insurgents. The heart of the Taliban and al-Qaeda insurgency is in Balochistan, the Northwest Frontier Province and the tribal belt along Pakistan's border with Afghanistan, known as the Durand Line. Top al-Qaeda and Taliban terrorists -- Osama bin Laden, his deputy Ayman al-Zawahiri, Muhammad Omar, Jalaluddin Haqqani and Gulbuddin Hekmatyar -- are believed to be operating from there. They are conducting military operations in Afghanistan and Pakistan. They are using the radio to spread propaganda against the West. And, most disturbing, they are using the border to set up camps, to recruit volunteers from the tribal population and to train them to build up their operations.

Pakistan cannot tackle the insurgents alone. These harsh mountainous areas have never been controlled or conquered by military forces. Aerial bombing raids by the Pakistani military to fight the insurgency only alienate the populace as civilians are killed and villages destroyed.

An effective counterterrorism strategy requires a global ground response to forge a cooperative relationship with the tribes that harbor the insurgents and the Frontier Corps responsible for border security. We need to offer them more than the insurgency is offering.

The 60 major tribes in the Northwest Frontier province and the tribal belt -- 77 additional tribes are in Balochistan -- are clustered along the 1,600-mile border. In each of these

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